



Crisis Communication and Stakeholder Management

GRC105 - Incident Management and Business Continuity (Cont'd)

Week 22-23 | January 5 - January 7

International Cybersecurity and Digital Forensics Academy
(ICDFA)

Effective Crisis Communication Protects Reputation and Maintains Stakeholder Trust

This module builds on incident response and business continuity by focusing on the critical communication dimension of crisis management. While technical response capabilities are essential, how an organization communicates during a crisis often determines whether it emerges stronger or suffers lasting reputational damage.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- 1 Understand Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) and its application to crisis response
- 2 Identify and analyze stakeholder groups with different communication needs during crises
- 3 Develop crisis communication plans with clear messaging, channels, and protocols
- 4 Apply spokesperson training principles and media relations best practices
- 5 Evaluate crisis communication case studies to extract lessons learned
- 6 Integrate crisis communication with incident response and business continuity programs

CONNECTION TO PREVIOUS WEEKS

WEEK 20

Incident Response Planning

Technical response to security incidents including detection, analysis, containment, eradication, and recovery procedures.

WEEK 21

Business Continuity & Disaster Recovery

Operational recovery and business resumption including BIA, recovery strategies, alternate sites, and testing programs.

WEEK 22-23

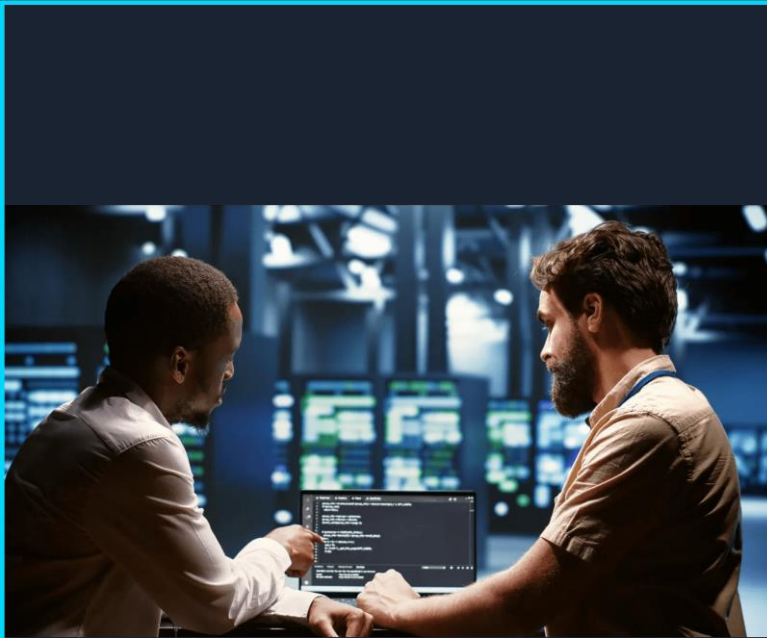
Crisis Communication & Stakeholder Management

Stakeholder communication and reputation management during crises to maintain trust and protect organizational credibility.

COMPREHENSIVE RESILIENCE

All three components work together to create comprehensive organizational resilience: technical response, operational recovery, and stakeholder communication.

Crisis Communication Manages Information Flow to Protect Reputation and Guide Stakeholders



DEFINITION

Crisis communication comprises the systems and protocols that enable organizations to communicate efficiently during disruption, mitigating reputational damage by asserting control.

KEY COMPONENTS

Strategic Function

Deliberate, planned control of information during crises

Stakeholder Focus

Meets needs of employees, customers, regulators, media, public

Reputation Protection

Primary goal is minimizing damage to credibility and trust

Control & Coordination

Establishes order through consistent, coordinated messaging

ISSUE

Problem that can be managed through normal communication over time

CRISIS

Sudden event requiring immediate response; threatens reputation or operations

THE CHANGING CRISIS LANDSCAPE

- 2020: sudden 51% > smoldering 49%
- Social media spreads faster, louder
- Stakeholders expect fast, open updates
- Less time to react than ever
- 24/7 news keeps crises alive

SCCT Provides Evidence-Based Framework for Matching Response Strategies to Crisis Situations

THEORY OVERVIEW

Developed by W. Timothy Coombs in 2007, SCCT suggests that crisis managers should match strategic crisis responses to the level of crisis responsibility and reputational threat posed by a crisis. Built on Attribution Theory and William Benoit's Image Restoration Theory.

CORE PRINCIPLE

The key to determining the most effective strategic crisis response is understanding the crisis situation and the amount of reputational threat being posed by the crisis.

REPUTATIONAL THREAT FACTORS

Initial Crisis Responsibility

How much stakeholders attribute the crisis to the organization

Crisis History

Whether organization has experienced similar crises before

Prior Relational Reputation

How organization has treated stakeholders historically

THREE CRISIS CLUSTERS

VICTIM CLUSTER

Minimal Responsibility Attribution

- Natural disasters
- Rumors
- Workplace violence
- Product tampering
- Organization is also a victim

ACCIDENTAL CLUSTER

Low Responsibility Attribution

- Technical error accidents
- Technical error product harm
- Challenges (stakeholders claim inappropriate operations)
- Unintentional failures

PREVENTABLE CLUSTER

Strong Responsibility Attribution

- Human error accidents
- Human error product harm
- Organizational misdeed with no injuries
- Organizational misdeed with injuries
- Organization knowingly placed people at risk

Match Communication Strategy to Crisis Type and Responsibility Level

DENY POSTURE

Lowest Accommodation

Strategies:

- **Deny:** No crisis exists or no responsibility
- **Attack Accuser:** Confront person/group claiming crisis
- **Scapegoat:** Blame external entity

Use When:

Rumor and challenge crises, when organization truly not responsible

DIMINISH POSTURE

Moderate Accommodation

Strategies:

- **Excuse:** Minimize responsibility (lack of intent or control)
- **Justification:** Minimize perceived damage from crisis

Use When:

Victim crises with history/negative reputation OR accident crises with no history/positive reputation

REBUILD POSTURE

High Accommodation

Strategies:

- **Compensation:** Offer money or gifts to victims
- **Apology:** Take full responsibility and ask forgiveness

Use When:

Accident crises with history/negative reputation OR all preventable crises

BOLSTER STRATEGIES (SUPPLEMENTAL)

- **Victimage:** Remind stakeholders organization is also victim
- **Reminder:** Remind stakeholders of past good works
- **Ingratiation:** Praise stakeholders and/or remind them of shared values

Use bolster strategies to supplement primary strategies, not replace them.

⚠ CRITICAL RULE

Maintain Consistency in Crisis Response Strategies

Mixing deny strategies with diminish or rebuild strategies will erode effectiveness of overall response. Choose one primary posture and stick with it throughout the crisis.

STRATEGY SELECTION GUIDE

Low Responsibility

Natural disasters, rumors, external attacks → Deny or Diminish

Moderate Responsibility

Technical failures, accidents, challenges → Diminish or Rebuild

High Responsibility

Human error, organizational misdeed, preventable harm → Rebuild

Effective Crisis Communication Requires Understanding Who Needs What Information When

STAKEHOLDER CATEGORIES

INTERNAL

- Employees (all levels)
- Board of Directors
- Executives & management
- Contractors & temp staff
- Labor unions

EXTERNAL

- Customers & clients
- Suppliers & vendors
- Partners & distributors
- Investors & shareholders
- Regulators & government
- Media (traditional & social)
- Community & public
- Industry associations

POWER/INTEREST GRID

HIGH POWER HIGH INTEREST

Manage Closely
Key players requiring most attention

HIGH POWER LOW INTEREST

Keep Satisfied
Important but don't overwhelm with info

LOW POWER HIGH INTEREST

Keep Informed
Want information, limited influence

LOW POWER LOW INTEREST

Monitor
Minimal effort, general awareness

ANALYSIS QUESTIONS

- What is their relationship to the organization?
- What are their expectations during a crisis?
- What information do they need?
- What channels do they prefer?
- What is their potential impact?
- Who are their trusted sources?

TAILORING COMMUNICATION BY STAKEHOLDER

Message Content

Level of detail, technical vs. general information

Message Tone

Formal vs. informal, empathetic vs. factual

Communication Channel

Email, social media, press release, town hall, one-on-one

Communication Frequency

Real-time updates vs. periodic summaries

Spokesperson

Executive, technical expert, PR professional, legal counsel

Key Principle

Different stakeholders require different approaches. One size does not fit all in crisis communication.

Preparation Before Crisis Enables Effective Response During Crisis

5 Steps to Creating an Incident Response Plan



CRISIS COMMUNICATION PLAN COMPONENTS

1. TEAM STRUCTURE

Crisis communication director, spokespersons, social media team, employee/customer communications leads, media relations, legal counsel, SMEs

2. CONTACT INFORMATION

Pre-compiled contact lists for all stakeholder groups, multiple contact methods, emergency notification systems, media database, regulatory contacts

3. CHANNELS & TOOLS

Primary and backup channels for each stakeholder group, mass notification systems, social media monitoring, website crisis page, email lists, hotline capabilities

4. MESSAGE TEMPLATES

Initial acknowledgment statement, situation update template, stakeholder-specific messages, FAQ document, social media responses, media statements, internal communications

5. APPROVAL PROCEDURES

Who approves messages before release, escalation path for different crisis severity levels, decision-making authority matrix, legal review requirements, regulatory triggers

6. MONITORING PROTOCOLS

Social media monitoring procedures, media monitoring and analysis, stakeholder sentiment tracking, rumor identification and correction, response time standards (15-20-60-90)

7. TRAINING & EXERCISES

Spokesperson media training, crisis communication team tabletop exercises, full-scale simulations, annual plan review and update, lessons learned integration

8. POST-CRISIS COMMUNICATION

Resolution announcement, lessons learned communication, reputation rebuilding activities, stakeholder feedback collection, return to normal operations communication

KEY PRINCIPLE

Crisis communication plans must be developed, documented, and tested before a crisis occurs. You cannot improvise effective crisis communication in the moment.

Speed Matters - Establish Communication Rhythm Within First 90 Minutes

THE GOLDEN WINDOW

The first 90 minutes of a crisis are critical for establishing credibility and controlling the narrative. Organizations that communicate quickly and effectively during this window have significantly better crisis outcomes.

15 MIN

ACKNOWLEDGE

- Confirm awareness of situation
- Activate crisis comm team
- Begin initial assessment
- Prepare holding statement

"We are aware of the situation and are currently gathering information. We will provide an update within the hour."

20 MIN

INITIAL STATEMENT

- Release first public statement
- Acknowledge what is known
- Express concern for affected
- Commit to providing updates

"We can confirm [basic facts]. Our top priority is [safety/resolution]. We are investigating and will provide updates every hour."

60 MIN

FIRST BRIEFING

- Provide more detailed information
- Outline immediate actions taken
- Address key stakeholder concerns
- Establish spokesperson

"Here's what we know: [details]. Here's what we're doing: [actions]. Here's what we don't yet know: [gaps]. Next update at [time]."

90 MIN

ESTABLISH RHYTHM

- Regular update schedule in place
- Monitoring and response system operational
- Stakeholder-specific communications underway
- Media relations active
- Internal communications flowing
- Social media presence established

WHY SPEED MATTERS

- Information vacuum fills with speculation and misinformation
- Stakeholders interpret silence as indifference or incompetence
- Media will find other sources if organization doesn't respond
- Social media amplifies criticism of slow responses
- First to communicate often controls the narrative

BALANCING SPEED AND ACCURACY

- Acknowledge quickly even if full information unavailable
- Clearly distinguish between confirmed facts and ongoing investigation
- Update as new information becomes available
- Correct misinformation promptly
- Never speculate or provide unverified information

Four Core Principles Guide Effective Crisis Communication

1 STAY CONSISTENT WITH YOUR MESSAGE

- Every communication should align with organization's overall narrative
- Consistency across all channels and spokespersons
- If transparency is priority, all updates must reflect this value
- Inconsistent messages create confusion and erode trust
- Coordinate messaging across departments and teams
- Single source of truth for all communicators

2 PRACTICE WHAT YOU PREACH

- Actions must match words
- If safety measures announced, implement them immediately
- If commitments made, deliver on them
- Hypocrisy destroys credibility faster than the crisis itself
- Stakeholders watch what you do, not just what you say
- Follow-through demonstrates integrity and competence

3 BALANCE SPEED WITH ACCURACY

- Timing is critical but accuracy is essential
- Acknowledge crisis quickly, provide details as verified
- Don't rush incomplete or unverified information
- Correct errors immediately if made
- "We don't know yet but are investigating" is acceptable
- Inaccurate information causes secondary crisis

4 LEAD WITH EMPATHY

- Recognize emotional impact of crisis on stakeholders
- Acknowledge concerns and fears
- Express genuine concern and compassion
- Tailor tone to situation severity
- Avoid appearing defensive or dismissive
- Put people before profits in messaging

ADDITIONAL BEST PRACTICES

Be Transparent

Share what you know, acknowledge what you don't

Take Responsibility

Own mistakes, don't deflect or make excuses

Avoid Jargon

Use clear, accessible language

Show Action

Communicate concrete steps being taken

Monitor Continuously

Track stakeholder reactions and adjust

Learn and Improve

Conduct post-crisis review and update plans

Effective Spokespersons Build Trust Through Credibility, Competence, and Composure

SPOKESPERSON SELECTION CRITERIA

AUTHORITY & CREDIBILITY

- Senior enough to demonstrate organizational commitment
- Subject matter expertise relevant to crisis
- Decision-making authority
- Trusted by stakeholders
- Appropriate for crisis severity

COMMUNICATION SKILLS

- Clear, confident speaker
- Comfortable with media
- Ability to simplify complex information
- Strong non-verbal communication
- Remains calm under pressure
- Empathetic and authentic

AVAILABILITY & COMMITMENT

- Available throughout crisis duration
- Willing to be public face
- Prepared for intense scrutiny
- Supported by backup spokespersons

SPOKESPERSON TRAINING COMPONENTS

MESSAGE DEVELOPMENT

- Crafting key messages
- Bridging techniques (transitioning to key points)
- Staying on message under pressure
- Handling difficult questions
- Avoiding speculation

MEDIA INTERVIEW TECHNIQUES

- Types of interviews (live, recorded, print, social media)
- Body language and non-verbal communication
- Voice tone and pacing
- Eye contact and engagement
- Handling hostile questions
- "No comment" alternatives

✓ DO

- Prepare and practice key messages
- Listen carefully to questions
- Pause before answering
- Correct inaccuracies
- Show empathy and concern
- Admit when you don't know something
- Commit to follow-up

✗ DON'T

- Say "no comment" (sounds evasive)
- Speculate or guess
- Use jargon or technical language
- Appear defensive or angry
- Make promises you can't keep
- Go "off the record"
- Fill silence with rambling

Social Media Amplifies Crises But Also Provides Powerful Communication Channel

CRISIS AMPLIFICATION

- Crises spread faster than ever through social media
- Anyone can become a publisher
- Viral content reaches millions in hours
- Emotional content spreads faster than factual content
- Misinformation and rumors proliferate
- Stakeholders expect real-time responses

CRISIS COMMUNICATION OPPORTUNITY

- Direct channel to stakeholders
- Rapid information dissemination
- Two-way communication and feedback
- Sentiment monitoring and analysis
- Rumor correction and fact-checking
- Humanizing organizational response

SOCIAL MEDIA CRISIS MANAGEMENT STRATEGY

1. MONITORING & DETECTION

- 24/7 social media monitoring
- Keyword and hashtag tracking
- Sentiment analysis tools
- Influencer identification
- Early warning indicators

2. RESPONSE PROTOCOLS

- Response time standards (minutes, not hours)
- Approval workflows for speed
- Pre-approved response templates
- Tone and voice guidelines
- Public vs. private response criteria

3. CONTENT STRATEGY

- Consistent messaging across platforms
- Platform-appropriate content
- Visual content (infographics, videos)
- Regular updates maintaining presence
- Proactive, not just reactive

TWITTER/X

- Real-time updates
- Brief, frequent posts
- Hashtag strategy
- Thread for detail

FACEBOOK

- Longer-form updates
- Community management
- Live video capabilities
- Comments moderation

LINKEDIN

- Professional tone
- Employee-focused
- Industry stakeholders
- Thought leadership

INSTAGRAM

- Visual storytelling
- Behind-the-scenes
- Employee stories
- Stories for real-time

⚠️ COMMON SOCIAL MEDIA MISTAKES TO AVOID

- Deleting negative comments (appears to hide truth)
- Slow or no response (interpreted as indifference)
- Defensive or argumentative tone
- Inconsistent information across platforms
- Ignoring influencers and amplifiers
- Automated responses to serious concerns
- Continuing normal marketing during crisis
- Failing to monitor after initial response
- Not addressing misinformation promptly

Employees Are Your Most Important Stakeholders and Powerful Ambassadors

EMPLOYEES AS STAKEHOLDERS

- Directly impacted by crisis
- Need information to do their jobs
- Concerned about job security and safety
- Have families and networks asking questions
- Can become advocates or critics

EMPLOYEES AS COMMUNICATORS

- Every employee is a spokesperson
- Personal networks trust employee voices
- Social media amplifies employee messages
- Positive employee communication builds credibility
- Negative employee communication damages reputation

INTERNAL COMMUNICATION PRIORITIES

1. INFORMATION NEEDS

- What happened and why
- How it affects them personally
- How it affects the organization
- What actions are being taken
- What is expected of them
- When they will receive updates
- Who to contact with questions

2. COMMUNICATION CHANNELS

- Email for detailed information
- Intranet for centralized updates
- Town halls for dialogue and Q&A
- Manager cascade for personal touch
- Hotline for questions
- Mobile apps for real-time alerts
- Team meetings for discussion

3. TIMING

- Employees should hear first, before external stakeholders
- Inform before they hear from media or social media
- Regular updates even if no new information
- Acknowledge uncertainty honestly
- Provide context and perspective

4. MESSAGING APPROACH

- Honest and transparent
- Acknowledge impact on employees
- Explain decisions and rationale
- Provide talking points for external conversations
- Show appreciation for their efforts
- Address fears and concerns directly
- Outline support resources available

5. EMPLOYEE SUPPORT

- Counseling and mental health resources
- Flexible work arrangements if needed
- Clear guidance on customer interactions
- FAQ document for common questions
- Manager training and support
- Recognition of extra efforts
- Career transition support if applicable

6. EMPOWERING EMPLOYEE ADVOCACY

- Provide accurate information
- Equip with key messages
- Trust them to communicate appropriately
- Encourage authentic sharing
- Recognize positive advocacy
- Address misinformation quickly

Marriott CEO's Authentic Video Message Demonstrated Power of Vulnerable Leadership

CASE BACKGROUND

The Crisis

In March 2020, COVID-19 pandemic devastated the hospitality industry. Marriott faced unprecedented crisis with occupancy rates plummeting, properties closing, and need to furlough tens of thousands of employees.

The Response

CEO Arne Sorenson recorded a 5-minute video message to employees. The video was raw, emotional, and deeply personal. Sorenson appeared visibly affected, his voice breaking as he discussed the difficult decisions ahead.

WHAT MADE IT EFFECTIVE

1. RAW EMOTION AND AUTHENTICITY

- Sorenson did not hide his emotions
- Voice cracked discussing furloughs
- No corporate polish or scripted delivery
- Genuine human leadership on display

2. PERSONAL VULNERABILITY

- Disclosed ongoing cancer treatment
- Explained his appearance (no hair)
- Shared personal struggle alongside organizational crisis
- Courage to be vulnerable built connection

3. TRANSPARENCY AND EMPATHY

- Openly described severity and business impact
- Explained necessity of furloughs and executive pay cuts
- Communicated support measures for employees
- Expressed real care and commitment to bring people back

KEY LESSONS LEARNED

Authenticity Over Polish

Genuine emotion resonates more than corporate perfection

Vulnerability Builds Trust

Leaders who show humanity create deeper connections

Transparency Is Essential

Honest communication about difficult decisions maintains credibility

Empathy Must Be Genuine

Stakeholders can distinguish real concern from performance

Video Humanizes Leadership

Visual communication conveys emotion better than text

Slack's Transparent Technical Communication Set Standard for Service Outage Response

CASE BACKGROUND

The Crisis

In February 2022, Slack experienced a major service outage affecting millions of users worldwide. The platform was completely unavailable for several hours, impacting businesses that depend on Slack for critical communication.

The Response

Slack's engineering and communications teams provided frequent, technically detailed updates via their status page, Twitter, and blog. They maintained transparency about the root cause, impact, and recovery progress throughout the incident.

WHAT MADE IT EFFECTIVE

1. FREQUENT UPDATES (EVERY 30-60 MINUTES)

- Updates posted every 30-60 minutes during active outage
- Prevented information vacuum and speculation
- Demonstrated urgency and commitment

2. TECHNICAL TRANSPARENCY

- Provided technical details about root cause
- Explained what systems were affected and why
- Shared recovery steps being taken

3. ACCOUNTABILITY AND OWNERSHIP

- Took full responsibility for the outage
- No deflection or blame-shifting
- Apologized sincerely for impact on customers

4. POST-INCIDENT COMMUNICATION

- Published detailed post-mortem analysis
- Outlined specific remediation steps
- Shared timeline of events and response

KEY LESSONS LEARNED

Update Frequency Matters

Technical Details Build Trust

Own the Problem

Post-Mortem Is Essential

Multiple Channels

Crisis Communication Completes the Organizational Resilience Framework

THE RESILIENCE TRIANGLE

INCIDENT RESPONSE

- Technical response to security incidents
- Detect, contain, eradicate threats
- Forensic investigation
- Restore normal operations

BC/DR

- Operational continuity during disruption
- Activate alternate sites and systems
- Restore critical business functions
- Meet RTO/RPO objectives

CRISIS COMMUNICATION

- Stakeholder information management
- Reputation protection
- Internal and external messaging
- Media and regulatory relations

INTEGRATION POINTS

SHARED ACTIVATION

All three teams activate simultaneously during major incidents. Crisis communication team needs real-time updates from IR and BC/DR teams.

COORDINATED MESSAGING

Technical findings from IR inform communication messages. BC/DR recovery timelines shape stakeholder expectations.

UNIFIED COMMAND

Single incident commander coordinates all three disciplines. Regular status meetings ensure alignment and information sharing.

STAKEHOLDER PRIORITIES

Crisis communication identifies key stakeholder concerns. IR and BC/DR teams prioritize actions based on stakeholder impact.

JOINT TESTING

Tabletop exercises include all three teams. Simulations test coordination, communication flows, and decision-making processes.

LESSONS LEARNED

Post-incident reviews include all three disciplines. Communication effectiveness evaluated alongside technical and operational response.

EXAMPLE: RANSOMWARE ATTACK COORDINATION

INCIDENT RESPONSE

- Isolate infected systems
- Identify ransomware variant
- Assess data encryption scope
- Determine attack vector
- Provide technical updates to crisis comm team

BC/DR

- Activate backup systems
- Restore critical functions from clean backups
- Establish recovery timelines
- Prioritize system restoration
- Communicate recovery status to crisis comm team

CRISIS COMMUNICATION

- Acknowledge incident within 15 minutes
- Update employees before external announcement
- Inform customers of service impact
- Provide recovery timeline updates
- Coordinate regulatory notifications

Effective Crisis Communication Protects Reputation and Guides Stakeholders Through Uncertainty



CORE PRINCIPLES RECAP

SCCT Framework

Match response strategy to crisis type and responsibility level

15-20-60-90 Timeline

Establish communication rhythm within first 90 minutes

Employees First

Internal stakeholders are most important and powerful ambassadors

Authenticity Over Polish

Genuine emotion and vulnerability build deeper trust

SUCCESS FACTORS

- **Preparation:** Plans, templates, training before crisis
- **Speed:** Acknowledge quickly, update regularly
- **Consistency:** Aligned messaging across all channels
- **Empathy:** Genuine concern for affected stakeholders
- **Continuous Learning:** Post-crisis review and plan updates

COMMON PITFALLS TO AVOID

- **Silence or Delay:** Vacuum fills with speculation
- **Inconsistent Messages:** Erodes credibility and trust
- **Defensive Posture:** Appears evasive or uncaring
- **Ignoring Employees:** Turns advocates into critics
- **No Follow-through:** Promises without action destroy reputation

NEXT STEPS: IMPLEMENTING YOUR CRISIS COMMUNICATION PROGRAM

1

Develop Your Plan

Create crisis communication plan with team structure, templates, and protocols

2

Train Your Team

Spokesperson training, media relations, social media management

3

Test Regularly

Tabletop exercises, simulations, and annual plan reviews

Thank You

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Crisis Communication and Stakeholder Management

KEY RESOURCES

FRAMEWORKS & STANDARDS

- **SCCT:** Situational Crisis Communication Theory by W. Timothy Coombs
- **NIST SP 800-61:** Computer Security Incident Handling Guide
- **ISO 22301:** Business Continuity Management
- **CISA:** Crisis Communication Resources

TOOLS & PLATFORMS

- **Social Media Monitoring:** Brandwatch, Sprout Social, Hootsuite
- **Crisis Management:** Everbridge, OnSolve, AlertMedia
- **Status Pages:** StatusPage.io, Atlassian Statuspage
- **Communication:** Slack, Microsoft Teams, Zoom

LEARNING RESOURCES

- **Books:** "Ongoing Crisis Communication" by W. Timothy Coombs
- **Organizations:** PRSA, IABC, Crisis Communication Network
- **Training:** Media training, spokesperson certification
- **Case Studies:** Harvard Business Review, PR News

QUESTIONS AND DISCUSSION

What crisis communication challenges are you facing in your organization?

How can you apply these frameworks and best practices to your context?

What steps will you take to strengthen your crisis communication capabilities?

INTERNATIONAL CYBERSECURITY AND DIGITAL FORENSICS ACADEMY

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NEXT WEEK

Continue building your organizational resilience capabilities